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Graduate School of Education & Information Studies
3101A Moore Hall
Box 951551
Los Angeles, CA 90095-1551

January 23, 2026

Distinguished Teaching Awards Selection Committee
UCLA Teaching and Learning Center

Dear Selection Committee:

I enthusiastically support Passion Lord for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award for Teaching Assistants. I write as Passion's faculty advisor and co- founder of the Bunche Fellows Program (BFP) in the Ralph J. Bunche Center for African American Studies. Passion was my BFP GSTA for 3 years, rising by sheer talent and commitment to lead GSTA and eventually co- instructor for our core, year- long BFP Seminar "Comparative Perspectives on the Study of Black Life."

BFP introduces underrepresented students to collaborative research and encourages pathways to graduate study, a mission Passion advances through targeted support. I have direct knowledge of Passion's teaching practice, pedagogical growth, and sustained impact. Over six quarters spanning three academic years, Passion has served as TA for four courses in African American Studies: AFAM 184A, 184B, 184C, and 188D. She demonstrates effective teaching grounded in student-centered, active, and inclusive pedagogy. She notices where students need support and collaborates with the instructor to respond thoughtfully.

For example, when students were unclear about a written assignment, Passion broke the task into structured checkpoints topic selection, outline, draft, and revision modeling each component before students attempted it. This scaffolded approach helped students develop presentation materials for the UCLA Undergraduate Research Showcase and Bunche Fellows Program Symposium, as well as writing samples for graduate school applications. Passion also builds participation through community practices that reduce anxiety and invite discussion, creating a climate where students feel safe taking intellectual risks. She addresses emerging instructional challenges, including helping students use generative AI ethically, teaching them to verify information, maintain critical thinking, and align AI use with learning goals.

Student feedback reflects these impacts. One student shared that Passion has been instrumental in supporting students… offering valuable assistance and guidance, and that her commitment to student success and knowledge of the course material have contributed to a positive learning environment. Another wrote: Passion is an absolutely amazing TA… She does a great job of making sure the classroom is welcoming, comfortable, and engaging.

Beyond required TA training, Passion has pursued substantial professional development, including AI pedagogy certification through the Association of College and University Educators (ACUE), UCLA training in Graduate Writing Pedagogy in English as a Second Language (Fall 2025), and designation as an Education Scholar through the Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning (CIRTL). Passion also conducts brief student surveys to assess whether assignment expectations are clear and to capture how students perceive their growth. She uses these findings to strengthen scaffolding, adjust activities, and improve feedback practices in real time, synthesizing insights to share at the American Educational Research Association (AERA) and Common Ground Consortium (CGC) conferences.

Passion designs coherent lessons where objectives, activities, and feedback work together to support student learning. She also mentors peers, sharing effective strategies and helping them build confidence. Passions' contributions have elevated teaching quality across our African American Studies courses. Students from her sections have gone on to medical school, law school, and graduate programs, outcomes reflecting her success in building the academic confidence students need for long-term success. I recommend Passion without reservation for this award.

Sincerely,



Walter R. Allen
Allan Murray Cartter Chair in Higher Education
Distinguished Professor of Education, Sociology and African American Studies

Self-Statement

As a Teaching Assistant in the Bunche Fellows Program, I have developed my practice around two commitments: implementing evidence-based strategies that directly address barriers to student learning, and pursuing professional development beyond required training to strengthen my pedagogical expertise.

The Bunche Fellows Program is an academic pipeline program in the Ralph J. Bunche Center for African American Studies at UCLA that supports underrepresented students in conducting original research. My teaching centers on a simple belief: students learn best when expectations are explicit, practice is structured, and classrooms are designed so that all learners can participate meaningfully and improve. I support students in developing confidence and competence in academic writing and public speaking, especially students who are multilingual, first-generation, or returning to school after time away, using research-based practices: transparent course design, active learning, timely feedback, and inclusive instructional strategies.

Identifying and Addressing Barriers to Student Learning

One barrier I routinely observe is that students often believe strong work is "innate" rather than learnable, leading to anxiety and uneven participation. To address this, I use transparent assignment design and structured scaffolding. I break major assignments into smaller checkpoints (topic selection, outline, draft, revision) and model each component before students complete it themselves. For instance, I demonstrate how to read and present research papers before students present their own work at the UCLA Undergraduate Research Showcase and Bunche Fellows Program Symposium. Each checkpoint includes clear criteria and examples of success, helping students understand expectations before attempting each task. This creates low-stakes opportunities that build confidence before higher-stakes presentations. Through this scaffolded approach, students create presentation slide decks, research posters, and writing samples for graduate school applications.

A second barrier is that students may not know how to revise effectively because they interpret feedback as judgment. I intentionally teach revision as a strategy, using targeted, actionable feedback paired with reflection prompts asking students to identify what they will change and why. This strengthens metacognition and helps students understand their own learning process.

A third barrier is uneven classroom participation. Many students, particularly those who are introverted or multilingual, may hesitate to speak in front of peers. I address this using active learning structures: low-stakes writing before discussion, think-pair-share, small-group collaboration, and guided prompts. These structures shift participation from a "confidence contest" to a learning routine, and students who were initially quiet contribute more consistently over time and report feeling more comfortable sharing ideas.

A fourth barrier is that students increasingly use generative AI without clear guidance about appropriate use. Students may either avoid AI entirely out of fear or use it in ways that

undermine learning. I teach students how to use AI responsibly, modeling how to create literature reviews while prompting effectively, verifying information, and maintaining critical thinking. I also introduce accessibility-focused uses, such as using Google Notebook to generate podcasts so students can engage with material while commuting. This approach supports ethical decision-making and aligns student behavior with learning goals.

Professional Development Beyond Required Training

To strengthen my teaching beyond required 495 training, I pursued formal professional development in AI pedagogy and effective instructional design. I earned AI-focused pedagogy training through the Association of College and University Educators (ACUE) to deepen my understanding of how students are using generative AI in writing and to design learning experiences that promote ethical, responsible, and transparent AI use. This training included assignment redesign in the age of AI, strategies for teaching responsible student use, building AI-inclusive and AI-resistant learning activities, developing course resources with AI, and writing effective prompts to support learning rather than shortcut it.

I also completed UCLA training in Graduate Writing Pedagogy in English as a Second Language (ESL) (Fall 2025), which strengthened my ability to teach writing and speaking across language backgrounds using research-based strategies such as scaffolding, modeling, and feedback practices that support revision and skill development.

Beyond coursework, I have engaged in the scholarship of teaching and learning to evaluate what helps students learn and to improve my practice based on evidence. Through the Bunche Fellows Program, I examined teaching and learning experiences to better understand which instructional approaches were most supportive for students. I also received training as an Education Scholar through the Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning (CIRTL), which emphasized reflective, evidence-informed teaching. I presented these teaching-and-learning findings at two educational conferences, the American Educational Research Association (AERA) and the Common Ground Consortium (CGC) Conference, demonstrating an ongoing commitment to improving my pedagogy and contributing to broader conversations about effective teaching.

Statement of Teaching

My teaching philosophy is grounded in a simple belief: students learn best when they feel intellectually challenged, personally supported, and genuinely seen. For many students, entering a university campus is their first experience in a setting where people may think, look, speak, and live differently than they do. In that transition, students encounter new perspectives that can challenge assumptions about identity, power, and community. My goal as an educator is to cultivate a learning environment where students, particularly historically marginalized students, can interrogate the beliefs and biases that shape how they move through the world. At the same time, I design my classroom as a space where students of all identities can share their lived experiences and connect them to historical and contemporary systems, whether examining environmental racism or Afro-Indigenous resistance. In African American Studies, I teach students to analyze Black life, history, and power using evidence, theory, and careful interpretation while developing the communication skills needed to articulate their ideas in academic and public contexts. In an undergraduate research program setting that prepares historically underrepresented students for graduate school, my sections bridge course concepts and research practice, helping students move from curiosity to researchable questions, claims, and analysis.

This philosophy shapes every pedagogical choice I make, from how I structure assignments and facilitate discussion to how I provide feedback and build classroom community.

I believe learning is not the passive reception of information, but an active process of construction, revision, and reflection. Students arrive with different experiences, preparation, and confidence levels; my role is to design learning opportunities that reduce unnecessary barriers while maintaining high standards. I aim to foster a classroom climate where students can take intellectual risks, ask unfinished questions, and revise their thinking without fear of embarrassment. I prioritize clear learning targets and explicit expectations through transparent assignment prompts, grading criteria, and models of strong work. I explicitly teach the "hidden curriculum" of academic success: how to read a prompt, cite evidence, build an argument, and move from summary to analysis, because these skills are often assumed rather than taught.

I value participation that supports learning rather than performative discussion. I structure sections around "doable but demanding" tasks that require students to practice scholarship in real

time. Through scaffolding, I provide feedback and challenge how students think. Because African American Studies is inherently interdisciplinary, I integrate communication-centered practices such as rhetorical analysis and media critique so students can translate complex ideas into clear arguments.

I aim to create learning environments where all students can engage deeply, including students who are first-generation, multilingual, returning, or balancing significant responsibilities. Inclusion shows up in practical choices: multiple ways to participate, clear discussion norms, accessible materials, and commitment to respectful dialogue, especially when course topics involve identity, power, and lived experience.

I treat feedback as teaching. I use rubrics aligned to learning outcomes and provide feedback that is specific and actionable: what to keep, what to adjust, and what to try next. When I notice patterns, I reteach the skill in sections, such as integrating quotations effectively or strengthening analytical transitions. I emphasize revision whenever possible, because learning is iterative and students should be rewarded for growth. For example, when I noticed students struggling to move from summary to analysis, I reteaught the skill using mentor texts and analytical sentence stems, modeling how to identify patterns across sources rather than simply reporting what each source said. Students who had been writing primarily descriptive paragraphs began producing more analytical work in their literature reviews and findings sections.

I begin each class with check-ins to monitor student progress, address questions, and connect students with campus resources when needed. I also incorporate interactive digital tools to promote engagement. Technologies such as Kahoot and Mentimeter allow students to practice concepts in low-stakes ways and build confidence before speaking in larger groups.

I also recognize that students increasingly use generative AI tools in their academic work. Rather than prohibiting these tools, I teach students to use them responsibly and transparently. I model appropriate uses such as generating study questions, organizing research notes, or summarizing dense readings while emphasizing that AI cannot replace their own critical thinking, original analysis, or engagement with sources. This prepares students for contexts where AI literacy is expected while ensuring they develop genuine scholarly skills.

Statement of Teaching

My goals are for students to leave my courses with the ability to: (1) interpret and analyze course texts using evidence; (2) construct and communicate arguments clearly in speaking and writing; (3) engage in scholarly dialogue by listening, questioning, and responding respectfully; (4) apply course concepts to lived realities and contemporary issues; and (5) develop academic confidence and belonging. In research-oriented settings, these goals include building research literacy: developing researchable questions, evaluating sources critically, practicing ethical citation, synthesizing scholarship, and communicating findings effectively through presentations, posters, and written reports.

I view teaching as a craft that requires ongoing development. Beyond required training, I actively pursue professional development to strengthen my pedagogical expertise. I have completed AI-focused pedagogy training through the Association of College and University Educators (ACUE), UCLA's Graduate Writing Pedagogy in English as a Second Language, and training as an Education Scholar through the Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning (CIRTL). I engage in the scholarship of teaching and learning, examining which instructional approaches best support student success and presenting findings at conferences including the American Educational Research Association (AERA) and the Common Ground Consortium. I regularly review student feedback and teaching notes to identify what supports learning, then revise activities, assignments, and supports accordingly.

Ultimately, I see myself as both an instructor and a learning partner, someone who helps students translate course goals into achievable steps and recognize their progress. I teach with structure and flexibility, rigor and care, and high expectations paired with meaningful support. My hope is that students leave not only with stronger analytical and communication skills, but also with a durable belief: their ideas matter, and they have the tools to make those ideas rigorous.

BFP Winter'26 Research Paper Guidelines

Deadline: March 17, 2026 at 11:59PM

Embarking on a research journey is a pivotal aspect of the Bunche Fellowship, where scholars are entrusted with the task of not only understanding the data provided by their esteemed faculty mentors but also expanding upon it through their unique research lenses. A research paper is not merely a scholarly requirement; it is a testament to the Fellows' ability to critically engage with information, contribute to their respective fields, and shape the narrative of their academic pursuits. Through this process, Bunche Fellows not only refine their analytical skills but also become active participants in advancing knowledge, making their mark in the realm of research and academia. The research paper stands as a tangible representation of their intellectual curiosity, dedication, and the transformative impact they bring to the academic landscape.

Your final paper should be no longer than 10 pages. While you will ultimately condense your work into this length, the outline you submit will be a crucial first step in organizing your thoughts and guiding the structure of your final paper.

Outline Requirements:

- The outline should be detailed, showcasing the key points, arguments, and structure you intend to use in your paper.
- Your outline should be a minimum of 4 to 5 pages in length, with each section clearly broken down.

Research Paper Content

Your research paper should include the following sections

- Cover Page - 1 page
- Abstract - 1 page
- Introduction
- Literature Review
- Methodology
- Findings
- Discussion
- References - does not count towards page limit
- Appendices - does not count towards page limit

General Research Paper Setup

- Set 1-inch margins on all sides of the document.
- Use Times New Roman with a 12-point size.
- Double-space the entire document

Cover Page

- Choose whatever citation you are comfortable using in your field (e.g APA, Chicago, MLA, etc.) One formatting style must be maintained throughout the entire annotated bibliography)
- Include a clear and concise title that reflects the content of your research.
- List your name, course title, instructor's name, and the date.
- Use a 12-point Times New Roman font, double-spaced lines, and maintain one-inch margins.

Abstract:

- Length: Your abstract should be a minimum of 100 words and should not exceed 1550 characters.
- Content: The abstract is a condensed version of your research, providing essential information:
    - Introduction: Introduce the background information.
    - Problem Statement: Clearly state the problem your research seeks to address.
    - Preview: Offer a glimpse of your main sources, data, or evidence.
    - Methodology/Conceptual Framework: Briefly outline your chosen methodology or conceptual framework.
    - Findings: Summarize the key findings from your study you have collected or expect to collect.
    - Significance: Discuss the anticipated significance of your research.
    - Please note: Should not include any in text citations

Example Abstract:

Each year, millions of Americans misuse opioids--and as sinister as drug use is for its immediate risk of death, it also plays a significant role in the contraction of the Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV). For intravenous drug users (IDUs), HIV contraction disproportionately affects Black Americans. The purpose of this paper is to examine the implications of race, HIV prevalence, and access to Syringe Safety Programs (SSPs) on Black IDU health outcomes. The literature used in this research comes from various experts in the fields of harm reduction, HIV, and the correlation between racial inequality and drug use. The findings of this research study identifies racial disparities in HIV contraction amongst IDU and its possible causes; the roots of harm reduction and its implementation of SSPs as an HIV

intervention strategy; and the rate of SSP use amongst Black American drug users. While Black American IDUs are at a higher risk of HIV contraction, it is not a cause of increased high HIV risk behavior; these disproportionate rates can be explained by various social implications including the Crack-Cocaine epidemic of the 1980s, overarching social inequality and proximity to areas of high HIV prevalence. Though SSPs are proven to lower contraction rates of HIV associated with drug use, Black Americans are least likely to get their sterile needles from SSPs. Overall, this research identifies significant gaps in research concerning the high prevalence of HIV and the underuse of SSPs amongst African American IDUs. Future research must be more intentional about conducting race-based studies concerning SSP accessibility and utilization; its use should be directed toward creating and expanding HIV intervention and treatment programs for Black IDUs.

Introduction

The introduction is the gateway to your research paper, providing a roadmap for readers to understand the context and significance of your study.

- **Introduce Background Information:**
    - Briefly describe the broader context of your research area.
    - Highlight critical concepts or developments relevant to your topic.
    - Connect your research to the wider field of study.
- **Clearly State the Problem:**
    - Define the specific problem or question your research seeks to address.
    - Explain why this problem is significant and warrants investigation.
- **Offer a Glimpse of Main Sources:**
    - Briefly mention key sources that influenced your study.
    - Provide a preview of the theoretical framework or major ideas guiding your research.

Literature Review

The literature review critically examines existing research, placing the authors collected during your annotated bibliography into a conversation.

- **Organize by Themes:**
    - Group sources based on common themes or concepts.
    - Analyze how different authors contribute to the understanding of your research problem.
- **Identify Gaps and Contradictions:**
    - Highlight areas where the literature lacks consensus or where gaps in research exist.

    - Discuss any conflicting findings or perspectives.
- **Synthesize Information:**
    - Integrate information from various sources to build a coherent narrative.
    - Demonstrate how your research fits into the broader scholarly conversation.

Research Methodology

The methodology section outlines your chosen research approach and design.

- **Specify Research Design:**
    - Describe whether your study is qualitative, quantitative, or mixed methods.
    - Justify your chosen design based on the nature of your research question.
- **Outline Data Collection Methods:**
    - Detail how the data was collected (surveys, interviews, experiments, etc.).
    - Discuss the rationale behind your chosen methods.
- **Address Ethical Considerations:**
    - Mention how ethical concerns, such as participant consent and confidentiality, were addressed.
    - Ensure transparency regarding any potential biases in your research.

Findings

Present your research results in a clear and organized manner.

- **Use Clear Headings:**
    - Organize findings using clear and informative headings.
    - Ensure each finding is presented logically and is easy to understand.
- **Visual Representation:**
    - Utilize tables, graphs, or charts to enhance the presentation of numerical data.
    - Include relevant quotes or excerpts from qualitative data.

Discussion

Analyze and interpret your findings, relating them back to your research question and existing literature.

- **Address Research Question:**
    - Clearly connect your findings to the initial research question.
    - Discuss how your results contribute to the broader understanding of the topic.
- **Compare with Existing Literature:**
    - Compare your findings with those from relevant studies in the literature.
    - Highlight similarities, differences, or new insights.

- **Discuss Implications:**
    - Discuss the practical and theoretical implications of your findings.
    - Address any limitations in your study and propose areas for future research.

References

- Choose whatever citation you are comfortable using in your field (e.g APA, Chicago, MLA, etc.)
- **Alphabetical Order:**
    - List all sources cited in alphabetical order by the author's last name.
    - Use a hanging indent for each citation.
- **Include Full Details:**
    - Provide complete information for each source, including author(s), publication year, title, source information, and DOI or URL.

Appendices

Include additional materials or data that are too lengthy for the main text.

- **Label Clearly:**
    - Clearly label each appendix (e.g., Appendix A, Appendix B).
    - Refer to appendices in the main text when necessary.
- **Include Relevant Supporting Documents:**
    - Attach any supplementary materials, such as surveys, interview transcripts, or raw data.
    - Ensure each item is relevant and enhances the reader's understanding.

Excerpt of written comments from SET surveys

On Creating a Supportive and Welcoming Learning Environment: "Passion is an absolutely amazing TA. She is truly one of a kind and I really don't want all her hard work to go unnoticed. She does a great job of making sure that the classroom is a welcoming, comfortable, and engaging environment and she is always very organized which makes everything so easy to follow."

"Passion is an angel on earth. Passion took care of everyone in the class. Passion is intentional, kind, intuitive, thoughtful, and makes you feel heard and respected. I have never had a TA like her and for that, I am most grateful. I had a very difficult school year and struggled with a physical condition in the Fall and chronic migraine throughout my life, with more episodes in the winter and spring quarter. Passion always took extra time out of her day to check in on me and genuinely cared about my well-being."

"Passion is very understanding and takes time to know the students as a whole person. Passion is an advocate for student rights and mental health and does her best to make sure that students succeed academically and mentally."

On Responsiveness and Student Support: "Passion is very responsive and incredibly supportive. You can tell that she really wants students to succeed while also taking care of themselves. I always appreciated Passion's willingness and eagerness to help and guide us."

"Passion always wants the best for all of us and was willing to hear all of us out to support us in any way possible. I really appreciated how understanding she and Asha were as I navigated the work this quarter."

"Passion consistently goes above and beyond to support students in our growth, especially with completing our respective research. Her approachable nature and genuine encouragement create a positive environment where we all feel motivated to ask questions when needed and succeed. Whether it's providing constructive feedback, or suggesting valuable resources, Passion is always here for us. 10/10 Black leader."

On Organization and Preparation: "Excellent TA, always prepared for discussions, and incredibly organized"

"Passion always seemed to be at the forefront of sending out messages, reminders, emails, posting class resources, and answering emails promptly. When I think of the Bunche Fellows Program, I immediately think of Passion and I think it is honestly due to her determined and passionate attitude, her preparedness for lectures and events, and going ABOVE and beyond to cater to all of our individual needs and goals."

On Impact on Student Success and Development: "Passion is truly the most kind–hearted, helpful, resourceful, and encouraging TA I have ever had at UCLA. All the resources she, along with other Bunche staff, help put together are resources that I will keep as a guide as I move along my career."

Excerpt of written comments from SET surveys

"Passion has been instrumental in supporting students in our African American course, offering valuable assistance and guidance throughout the semester. Her commitment to student success and her knowledge of the course material have contributed to a positive learning environment, she encourages student participation and engagement in discussions, and is approachable and responsive to student inquiries and concerns."

"Passion was an excellent TA and honestly a highlight for many of us students in the class. She is extremely prepared for every class, very thorough and organized, and incredibly empathetic and kind. She is a great person to learn from and felt glad that I met her through this class with my peers. She is a jewel and UCLA should feel honored to have her as a TA."

On Collaborative Teaching and Leadership:

"The class was divided into two TA–led groups, and I had the privilege of working primarily with Passion Lord. From day one, her light was undeniable. She's organized, attentive, and incredibly generous with her time and support. Her passion for teaching and research made our group feel like a true learning community, and she created a space where I felt encouraged and capable. Asha Fletcher brought a calm confidence and strength from the sciences that perfectly complemented Passion's energy. Together, they brought a dream team energy to the course. Their different backgrounds created a natural balance between the humanities and the sciences, which enriched every aspect of the learning environment. I genuinely can't think of any weaknesses, just appreciation for how well they supported us and each other throughout the term. 10 Stars!"

"Passion always prioritizes helping everyone in the BFP cohort. I appreciate the food provided and the mental health/research update questions. So far all the discussions have been fruitful and I look forward to next quarter. I was impressed with Passion's presentation of Dr. Allen's research and her leadership makes me feel more confident to be in this program. I commend her on her personal research under Dr. Allen. The standard has already been set high about what the TA's bring so there's not much I can say to improve."

On Overall Excellence: "Passion has great energy and is really dedicated to holistically supporting students in their research/ personal development. She's great"

"She is a perfect TA."

"Very understanding and very helpful toward the students"

"Amazing TA"

"Great at leading the course and giving clear instructions!"

"This attitude made us feel like we could accomplish anything, especially during times when numerous challenges and conflicts were occurring on campus. Overall, Passion is an excellent TA and UCLA should feel lucky to have her as a student, TA, and future graduate."

BFP Winter'26 Research Paper Outline Guidelines

Annotated Bibliography Due: February 17th, 2026

Embarking on a research project is an exciting aspect of the Bunche Fellowship that demands careful planning and organization. A well-structured research outline serves as your roadmap, guiding you through the complexities of your investigation and ensuring a successful scholarly endeavor. By outlining your research, you gain a comprehensive understanding of your project and unlock several advantages.

- A well-crafted research outline provides clarity on the objectives and scope of your study, helping you stay focused on your research goals.
- An outline enables you to allocate your time effectively, ensuring that each phase of your study receives the attention it deserves.
- A structured outline ensures consistency and cohesion in your work. It aids in organizing your thoughts, maintaining a logical flow, and preventing disjointed or scattered research findings.

Research outlines must be approved by both the BFP team and faculty mentors. This collaborative approval process ensures alignment with program expectations and academic standards. Please submit your research outlines by February 18th to facilitate timely feedback and guidance as you progress on your research journey.

Outline Content

Your Research outline should include the following sections

- Cover Page
- Annotated Bibliography

General Outline Setup:

- Set 1-inch margins on all sides of the document.
- Use Times New Roman with a 12-point size.
- Double-space the entire document, including the title page and annotated bibliography.

Cover Page:

- Title: Craft a concise title (maximum 200 characters) that accurately reflects the essence of your research. Avoid using formatting like italics or bold.
- Authors: Include the names of the authors. (Your name and faculty mentor's name)

Example Title:

The Impact of Race on the Accessibility of Harm Reduction Resources

Kylie Paramore & Dr. Walter Allen

Annotated Bibliography

- Include a minimum of 2 or 3 sources in your bibliography.
- Choose whatever citation you are comfortable using in your field (e.g APA, Chicago, MLA, etc.) One formatting style must be maintained throughout the entire annotated bibliography)
- Ensure you include literature recommended or provided by your faculty mentor along with externally collected resources.
- Accompany each source with a 200-word maximum paragraph, providing information to answer the following questions for each source:

What is the purpose of this source?

- What type of source is this (research study, review article, opinion piece, report)?
- What question or problem does the author address?
- Who is the intended audience?
- What is the author's main argument or thesis?

What are the key findings from this source?

- What are the main conclusions or results?
- What evidence or data does the author present?
- Are there any surprising or significant discoveries?
- What methods did the author use (if applicable)?

How does this source contribute to your research?

- How does this source relate to your research question or thesis?
- Does it provide background information, evidence, or counterarguments?
- What gap does it fill in your understanding?
- How does it compare to or complement your other sources?
- Does it support, challenge, or complicate your argument?

Tip: Don't feel obligated to answer every question for each source. Select the 2 to 3 most relevant questions per section that best capture what matters about that particular source for your research. Focus on being concise and specific rather than comprehensive.

Example Annotated Bibliography Entry:

Guiffrida, Douglas A. "African American Student Organizations As Agents of Social Integration." Journal of College Student Development 44, no. 3 (2003): 304-319. https://doi.org/10.1353/csd.2003.0024.

In his 2003 article, Guiffrida, a professor of counseling and development at the University of Rochester, examines the role of African American student organizations in fostering social integration. The study delves into the challenges faced by African American students in predominantly White environments, despite societal emphasis on diverse collaboration. Navigating a campus where Black students are a minority poses difficulties in forming close relationships with White peers. The excerpt highlights initial feelings of isolation and the subsequent pursuit of comfort through association with fellow Black students. Guiffrida's exploration sheds light on the complex dynamics and the crucial role of support networks for African American students striving to navigate and integrate into predominantly White academic environments. The study underscores the significance of understanding these experiences to foster inclusive and supportive campus climates. This study is relevant to the research being conducted by highlighting the importance of spaces like the Ralph J. Bunche Center.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES

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DEPARTMENT OF INTEGRATIVE BIOLOGY AND PHYSIOLOGY
612 CHARLES E. YOUNG DRIVE SOUTH
BOX 957246
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-7246

January 27th, 2026

Dear Selection Committee,

It is my great pleasure to recommend Passion Lord for the Distinguished Teaching Award at the University of California, Los Angeles. I have supervised Passion since Fall 2023 in her role as a teaching assistant for the Bunche Fellows Program (BFP) undergraduate seminar courses, AFAM 184 and AFAM 188, housed in the Ralph J. Bunche Center for African American Studies. Over multiple academic terms, I have had the opportunity to observe her teaching closely, and she stands out as one of the most effective and dedicated teaching assistants I have supervised.

The BFP seminar is a yearlong, research-intensive course sequence that introduces undergraduates to the full arc of scholarly inquiry, including research design, academic writing, analysis, and public presentation. The seminar challenges students to move from acquiring knowledge to producing original research, while centering the study of Black life with intellectual rigor, care, and respect. For many students, this course is foundational in helping them achieve scholarly excellence within a large research university.

Within this demanding and meaningful context, Passion plays a central instructional role. She has taken primary responsibility for designing and facilitating instruction that thoughtfully scaffolds the research process across the academic year. She consistently anticipates and addresses common barriers to student learning, including uncertainty about academic expectations, uneven participation, and limited exposure to empirical research. To support students, she employs research-based pedagogical strategies, including transparent assignment design, explicit modeling of research tasks, and structured opportunities for practice and feedback. Her teaching is exceptionally clear, well-organized, and carefully sequenced, enabling students to build skills progressively. This is especially evident in students' strong preparation for the UCLA Undergraduate Research Showcase and the Bunche Fellows Research Symposium, where they routinely present polished and well-supported work.

What most distinguishes Passion's teaching is her attentiveness to how students learn and where they struggle. Recognizing that many Bunche Fellows are encountering academic research for the first time, she explicitly teaches skills often left implicit, such as interpreting prompts, revising writing meaningfully, engaging with feedback, and participating in scholarly discussion. She regularly incorporates active learning strategies, including low-stakes writing, small-group work, and guided discussion, to promote equitable participation and build confidence. As a result, students who initially doubt their abilities develop the competence and self-assurance to see themselves as capable researchers.

Passion also demonstrates a deep commitment to her growth as an educator. She has pursued extensive professional development in graduate writing pedagogy, English as a Second Language instruction, and ethical approaches to the use of generative AI in the classroom. She continually reflects on student progress and adapts her instruction accordingly, approaching teaching as an evolving and intellectually engaged practice.

In sum, Passion Lord is an exceptional teaching assistant whose work in AFAM 184 and 188 powerfully advances the academic and cultural mission of the BFP. Her teaching has had a lasting impact on students' intellectual development, confidence, and preparation for graduate study. I offer my strongest and most enthusiastic recommendation for her nomination for the Distinguished Teaching Award.

Best Regards,



Ketema N. Paul, Ph.D.
Professor, Integrative Biology and Physiology
Co-Director, Bunche Fellows Program